Blameless Incident Review

Learn from an incident without blame: what happened, why it made sense at the time, and how to make it less likely.

Improve · Blameless Post-Incident Review · Learning from Incidents · Systems, Not People

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

INCIDENT: Checkout outage, Sat 5 April

REVIEW DATE: 9 April

1 Summary

FACTS ONLY

What happened: checkout failed for most customers

Detected by / how: customer service: complaints

Impact (who, how long): ~3,000 orders, 4 hours

Duration to recover: 4 hours (09:10–13:10)

Severity: ☐ 1 · critical ☑ 2 · major ☐ 3 · minor ☐ 4 · near miss

2 Ground Rules

READ ALOUD AT THE START

- ☑ We look at systems, not at who to blame
- ☑ People did what made sense with what they knew
- ☑ Curiosity over judgement: ask “how”, not “who”
- ☑ What we learn is shared openly

3 Timeline

WHAT DID PEOPLE KNOW AT EACH POINT?

TIME	WHAT HAPPENED	WHAT WE KNEW THEN	WHAT WE DID AND WHY
08:55	Payment provider rotated its API certificate	nothing: no alert on certificate errors	nothing; we didn't know
09:10	Payments start failing at checkout	a few complaints, looked like card issues	customer service told people to retry
10:30	Complaints spike; customer service escalates	something is wrong with checkout	Sam paged; looked at our last release
11:40	Logs show certificate errors to the provider	it's the provider's change, not ours	Platform team joined; rolled back the release
13:10	New certificate installed; checkout recovers	the fix worked	watched for 30 minutes, then closed it

4 Contributing Factors

USUALLY SEVERAL · RARELY ONE ROOT CAUSE

Technology

- No alert on certificate errors
- Rollback took 40 min

Process

- Provider changes not shared with us

Knowledge

- Only Sam knew the payment setup

Environment

- Saturday: fewer people around

Communication

- Customer service had no way to escalate quickly

5 What Helped

- Customer service spotted it
- Platform joined fast

6 Where We Got Lucky

- Not on a big promo day
- Sam happened to be free

7 Follow-up Actions

PREVENT · DETECT SOONER · RECOVER FASTER

ACTION	TYPE: PREVENT / DETECT / RECOVER	OWNER	DUE	
Alert on payment-provider errors over 2%	detect	Platform	16 May	+ 3 more in the RAID log

“Why did it make sense to them at the time?”

“What would make the next incident less likely, or easier to recover from?”

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